

Pushpa: The Rise – Part I
[Dec. 2021]

2021's highest grosser starring **ALLU ARJUN**, the Telugu film revived single-screen cinemas post the second wave. Its soundtrack has 5 bn views on YouTube

Nationwide	Hindi dubbed
₹323 crore	₹108 crore

for almost nine years, then got his due in 1962," says Arjun. Arjun's father, Allu Arvind, is one of Telugu film industry's leading producers. Arvind's sister, Surekha, is married to Telugu superstar Chiranjeevi. On October 1, 2020, coinciding with the 99th birth anniversary of his grandfather, the family announced the launch of Allu Studios in West Hyderabad.

Allu Arjun's own cinematic journey began in 2003 with *Gangotri*, but didn't bring him notice as an actor. It was Sukumar who noticed the 20-year-old "bubbly" Arjun easily mingling with everyone at a screening of the Telugu film *Dil*. The filmmaker was convinced he had found his Arya, an eponymous film that would go on to make Allu Arjun popular even in Kerala where he is known as 'Mallu Arjun' and has multiple fan clubs. Sukumar also gave Arjun the sobriquet 'Icon Star'. "He is one of my closest friends," says Arjun of the 52-year-old filmmaker. "I can share a lot of my whims and fancies with him on what I want to do on screen. He will take what is required and project it. He sees me like nobody does." *Pushpa*'s music director Devi Shri Prasad, too, is a childhood friend of Arjun's.

In a film industry teeming with stars, be it Prabhas, Mahesh Babu, Ram Charan, Jr NTR, Pawan Kalyan, Nani and sexagenarian legends such as Chiranjeevi and Nagarjuna, Allu Arjun is also known as the 'Stylish Star' courtesy his "urban swag" and dancing prowess evident in viral songs like '*Butta Bomma*'. "I give credit to my upbringing in Chennai and to MTV," says Arjun. The actor changes his look for each film and has given us hits like *Arya 2* (2009), *S/O Satyamurthy* and *Rudhramadevi* (2015), *Sarrainodu* (2016), *DJ: Duvvada Jagannadham* (2017) and *Ala Vaikunthapurramuloo* (2020).

But missing in Allu Arjun's illustrious filmography to date is a collaboration with India's most celebrated pop epicist, S.S. Rajamouli. "Every actor in the Telugu industry wants to work with Rajamouli," he says. "Hopefully, Inshallah, it happens." With his latest magnum opus, Rajamouli showed it is possible to bring together two stars of Telugu cinema—Ram Charan, son of Chiranjeevi, and Jr NTR, grandson of the legendary actor and former Andhra Pradesh chief minister N.T. Rama Rao. Charan and Jr NTR channelled the valour of the two freedom fighters in a high-octane action drama with friendship at its core. Their vigorous moves in '*Naatu Naatu*' were a joy to behold.

THE DREAMER, THE ACHIEVER

Unlike Allu Arjun who comes from an illustrious film family, Yash, a.k.a. Naveen Kumar Gowda, is an outsider who had to struggle to find a way in. He grew up in Mysore, his father a bus driver with the state-run transport service BMTC. As a teenager, he helped run a provision store the family owned. He was always addicted to applause and attention, he has said in interviews, even as a child. It took him to big town Bengaluru when he was not even 18, to the theatre repertory Bengaluru Nagara Kalavidaru, better known by its acronym Benaka. Chasing a career in showbiz wasn't